

UTM Tagging Guide



A complete playbook for tracking marketing campaigns across every channel — from tagging setup to naming conventions and the mistakes that quietly break attribution.

```
https://yoursite.com/landing?utm_source=facebook&utm_medium=cpc&utm_campaign=spring_launch&utm_term=cart_abandoners&utm_content=video_a
```



DATAWIZ ANALYTICS

Web datawizanalytics.com

Email igor@datawizanalytics.com

What are UTM tags?

UTM tags (Urchin Tracking Module parameters) are short pieces of text appended to a URL that tell your analytics platform exactly where a visitor came from. Without them, all paid social traffic looks the same. With them, you can tell *"Facebook video ad targeting cart abandoners"* from *"Facebook static ad targeting lookalikes"* — and decide where to spend the next dollar.

Anatomy of a tagged URL

Every UTM-tagged URL follows the same structure: a base URL, a question mark to start the parameter string, and key-value pairs joined by ampersands.

```
https://yoursite.com/page?utm_source=facebook&utm_medium=cpc&utm_campaign=spring_launch&utm_term=cart_abandoners&utm_content=video_a
```

- Source**
Allows you to track where traffic originated. Sources may include Facebook, Google, a partner's website, or the email provider.
- Medium**
Allows you to track the type of marketing channel that brought users to the website. This should be the largest "bucket" for grouping traffic, such as paid search, email, social, organic, referral, or display.
- Campaign**
Allows you to track the performance of a specific marketing campaign. This helps separate results between different campaigns, even when they come from the same source or medium.
- Term**
Allows you to analyze how specific keywords or targeting options are performing. Examples may include search terms like running shoes, protein powder, or web analytics agency, as well as targeting options like interest groups, audiences, or ad groups.
- Content**
Allows you to track which specific ad variation users clicked. This can include the ad headline, slogan, short copy, creative angle, ad format, or another detail that helps distinguish one ad from another.

The five parameters explained

Each parameter answers one specific question about your traffic. Used together, they paint a complete picture of which channel, campaign, audience, and creative drove a particular visit.

Source `utm_source`

REQUIRED

Where is the traffic coming from?

Examples: google bing facebook twitter newsletter linkedin

Medium `utm_medium`

REQUIRED

What channel are you using to promote your website?

Examples: cpc organic affiliate social email referral display

Campaign `utm_campaign`

REQUIRED

What are you promoting?

Examples: summer_campaign black_friday new_product_release webinar_q3

Term `utm_term`

RECOMMENDED

Which targeting options or keywords did you use?

Examples: males_over25 cart_abandoners basketball_fans_boston running_shoes

Content `utm_content`

RECOMMENDED

What copy or creative did you use?

Examples: short_copy social_proof dynamic_video hero_banner cta_button

UTM tagging by channel

Recommended naming conventions for each platform. The reference below shows the three value types you'll see in the templates.

meta

Fixed value — use exactly as written, no changes

`{{campaign.name}}`

Platform variable — auto-populated at click-time

`[email_type]`

Manual variable — you fill this in when creating the link

G Google Ads

Auto-tagged via GCLID — do not add UTM parameters. Google Ads automatically appends a GCLID parameter that Google Analytics uses for full attribution, including ad spend.

M Meta Ads

Source	meta
Medium	cpc
Campaign	<code>{{campaign.name}}</code>
Term	<code>{{adset.name}}</code> <code>{{placement}}</code>
Content	<code>{{ad.name}}</code>

S Surfside

Source	surfside
Medium	display
Campaign	<code>{{source id}}</code>
Term	<code>{{strategy id}}</code> <code>{{placement id}}</code>
Content	<code>{{creative id}}</code>

@ Email

Source	alpine
Medium	email
Campaign	<code>[email_type]</code>
Term	<code>[audience_segment]</code>
Content	<code>[variant]</code>

Social Media

Source	<code>[platform_name]</code>
Medium	social
Campaign	<code>[post_name]</code>
Term	—
Content	—

G Google My Business

Source	gmb
Medium	listing
Campaign	<code>[location]</code>
Term	—
Content	—

W Weed Maps

Source	weed_maps
Medium	listing
Campaign	[location]
Term	—
Content	—

A Apple Maps

Source	apple_maps
Medium	listing
Campaign	[location]
Term	—
Content	—

L Other Listings

Source	other_listing
Medium	listing
Campaign	[location]
Term	—
Content	—

UTM tagging best practices

UTM tracking only works as a team sport. One person writing `fb`, another writing `facebook`, and a third writing `meta` fragments your data into three sources that should be one. Follow these rules so your data stays clean.

1

Use consistent naming conventions

Document approved values for source, medium, and campaign in a shared style guide. Standardize on one spelling per concept — never let "facebook" and "fb" coexist.

2

Always use lowercase

UTMs are case-sensitive in GA4. `Facebook`, `facebook`, and `FACEBOOK` appear as three different sources. Enforce lowercase across the whole team.

3

Never tag internal links

UTMs on links inside your own site overwrite the original traffic source, create false sessions, and inflate your numbers. Only tag external links pointing into your site.

4

No spaces or special characters

Avoid `?`, `%`, `&`, `#`, `!`, `@`, and spaces. Use hyphens to separate words (`spring-sale`) or underscores when two words form one concept (`cart_abandoners`).

5

Verify URL shorteners preserve UTMs

Some shorteners strip query strings on redirect. Always click a shortened test link and confirm the UTMs land intact at the destination URL.

6

No personal information in tags

Never include emails, phone numbers, names, or any PII in UTM values. Tagged URLs end up in browser history, referrer headers, and server logs — assume they are public.

7

Don't repeat information across parameters

If your source is `facebook`, don't also put "facebook" in the campaign name. Each parameter should carry unique, non-overlapping information.

8

Test before every launch

Click each tagged URL pre-launch. Verify the UTMs appear in the address bar and that the visit shows up correctly in your analytics platform with the expected source, medium, and campaign.

Do this, not that

A side-by-side reference for the most common UTM decisions. When in doubt, default to the left column.

✓ Do

- Use lowercase only: `facebook`
- Replace spaces with hyphens: `spring-sale`
- Pick one spelling per concept and stick with it
- Add UTMs to every external campaign link
- Use auto-tagging where the platform offers it
- Maintain a shared naming-convention document
- Test every URL before launching

✗ Don't

- Mix cases: `Facebook` vs `facebook`
- Use spaces or special chars: `?` `%` `&` `#` `!` `@`
- Tag internal links inside your own site
- Put PII (emails, names, phones) into UTMs
- Repeat the source name in the campaign field
- Trust shorteners without checking they preserve UTMs
- Invent ad-hoc parameters like `utm_team`

The four most expensive mistakes



Inconsistent capitalization fragments your data

GA4 treats `Email` and `email` as different mediums. A team using both ends up with split rollups that look like two underperforming channels instead of one healthy one.



Tagging internal navigation

UTMs on internal links overwrite the original traffic source. A user from Google who clicks an internal banner gets re-attributed to the banner — destroying upstream attribution.



Swapping source and medium

Source is *who* sent the traffic (facebook, google, newsletter). Medium is *how* it arrived (cpc, email, social). Swapping them breaks every cross-channel comparison.



Skipping the pre-launch test

Catching a broken UTM before launch takes 30 seconds. Diagnosing missing attribution after a two-week campaign already ran takes hours — and the data you lost is gone for good.